

“When you visit Haiti, it’ll break your heart, and when you leave, you won’t take back all the pieces.”
■ **Haitian proverb**



■ A boy races a horse down Rue Nationale #3 near the village of Bohoc, where Southwest Florida missionaries work. The road is Haiti’s third main highway, connecting the cities and towns of the Central Plateau, north of Port-au-Prince. Leaders have talked about repairing the highway over the years, but it remains riddled with potholes. A four-mile drive can take 30 minutes.

Haiti’s hope

Its people are among the poorest in the world. Every day, they struggle to feed and clothe their families and educate their children. Many residents of this Caribbean nation rely on a network of Southwest Florida volunteers, health care workers and missionaries who have reached out to help. Together, they share a faith in Haiti’s future.

STORIES BY **MIRIAM PEREIRA** | PHOTOGRAPHS BY **ANDREW WEST**



■ Pastor Jean Oracius prays as children sit to eat a lunch of rice and beans at a small school in the mountain village of Bonody. Oracius helps part-time Southwest Florida resident Pastor Georges Joseph run the school.

WHERE THEY WENT

The News-Press staffers Andrew West and Miriam Pereira traveled to Haiti in April. They visited remote mountain villages and sprawling neighborhoods in the capital, Port-au-Prince. Here is a look at the places they visited:

1 The Haitian American Friendship Foundation, a mission near the town of Pignon in the Central Plateau.
2 The capital, Port-au-Prince, where they visit Pastor Georges Joseph's orphanage, school and church.
3 Joseph's orphanage and school atop a mountain in the village of Bonody, near Cavaillon.
4 Valère to see Joseph's school, which also serves as a church.
5 Fond Parisien to visit Love A Child mission.



Haiti fast facts



Population: Nearly 8 million

Climate: Tropical, semi-arid, rugged and mountainous

Official languages: French and Creole

Size: Comparisons: Haiti is about the size of Maryland

ONLINE



news-press.com/haiti
Go in-depth with our multimedia report. It includes:

- An audio/visual slide show, narrated by the photographer and author of today's special section.
- Video interviews with Haitians living in Southwest Florida.
- Balancing Cultures: An interactive special report on six of our region's emerging ethnic groups.
- Haiti in turmoil: A profile of the nation, with an emphasis on history, politics and the environment.
- Images from the uprising: A photo gallery of street scenes from Aristide's ouster.
- A timeline depicting the history of Haiti.
- Recordings of Haitian music espousing hope, faith and love.
- Readers' forums: What life lessons do you take from this story of Haiti's hope? What should foreign governments do to ensure a better future for Haiti? What can ordinary people in Southwest Florida do?

PROJECT TEAM

PHOTOGRAPHER
- **Andrew West**, 36, is an award-winning photographer who has covered many stories on Southwest Floridians, including tracking a group up Mount Kilimanjaro. He's also photographed the Tampa Bay Buccaneers' Super Bowl win and the riots that erupted in Miami after U.S. authorities returned Elian Gonzalez to Cuba. A graduate of the Art Institute of Fort Lauderdale, he has worked at The News-Press for seven years.

WRITER
- **Miriam Pereira**, 35, is an assistant lifestyles editor. When not on special assignment, she writes a weekly column about her life as a Cuban-American. Among the news stories she's covered: the plight of farmworkers who crossed the Mexican border to work in Southwest Florida's tomato fields. A journalism graduate of Florida International University in Miami, she has worked at The News-Press for nine years.

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Simple pleasures bring hope to Haitians



MIRIAM PEREIRA

Last month, I went to Haiti. Stepping onto the runway at the international airport in Port-au-Prince was like stepping back in time. Stairs led to the tarmac. There were no jetways at the aging terminal, which was surrounded by mango trees and shanties.

Armed Canadian soldiers stood in watchtowers near rows of olive green tents. Military helicopters nearby seemed ready for patrol at a moment's notice.

The day before, when we left Fort Myers, the employee at a car rental company looked at News-Press photographer Andrew West and me and smiled. "Are you going on vacation?" she asked.

I kind of laughed, but didn't share my thoughts. "Does anyone go to Haiti on vacation?"

The first black republic in the Western Hemisphere, Haiti also holds the distinction of being the poorest country there. In the 200 years since it was founded, it's gone through numerous leaders who have promised much and delivered little to their people. Almost four months ago, Haiti went through yet another in a long list of bloody revolts. Haitians have struggled for years with chaos, fear and violence.

Then there's the poverty. As we walked through the airport, Haitian men in tattered clothing swarmed us and tried to grab our suitcases.

"One dolla, one dolla," they said, using the few English words they knew.

They needed the money. They needed to eat. As the days passed, I quickly realized the situation wasn't much different anywhere else in the country.

In Port-au-Prince, donkeys grazed in grassy fields. Women cooked pots of beans by the roadside. Children without shoes walked unpaved streets.

I saw the same poverty in mountain villages north of the city. There, we hiked two hours through steep hills to visit a church built on concrete blocks. When the wind blew, the rusty tin roof rattled.

We were invited to visit a family of 10. They lived in an 8-by-10-foot room. The toddlers stumbled on rocks in the yard, their thin legs coated in dust. The older siblings chewed sugar cane to stave off hunger.

"How could people live like this?" I wondered.

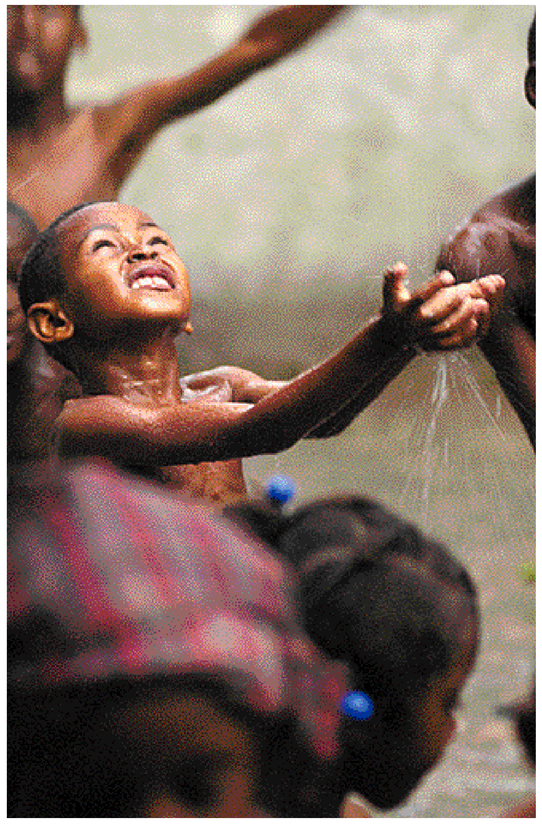
But at least in the mountains, people can breathe. In Port-au-Prince, the stench of rotting food, burning charcoal and animal waste permeated almost everything — my clothes, my hair, my skin. The smell didn't bother the children who live at an orphanage run by Pastor Georges Joseph. They are grateful to have a place to eat, a place to sleep and a place to learn.

They were intrigued by the American *blancs*, as whites are called. The boys gazed curiously at Andrew's digital cameras and the laptop he used to download his images. They had never seen such things. The girls examined me as if I were from another planet. They touched my skin, caressed my face and braided my hair, fascinated by long curls — something else they had never seen.

Like the men at the airport, some wanted money. "Give me one dolla," they demanded.

Others pointed to my dusty shoes, my $10 watch, my sweaty shirt. "Give me," they said.

It was too much, but I had work to do. I couldn't stop and think about it at that moment. Instead, I continued to talk to people, collect information and report my stories.



■ The sky opens, unleashing rain on Madoché Andre and the other children at Georges Joseph's orphanage near Port-au-Prince. They strip and gather under a drainpipe, playfully shoving each other as they take turns bathing in the sheets of water. The storm brings a few moments of joy.

At night, I would escape by sitting on the porch and struggling to breathe the foul air. I longed for the mountains. Sometimes, Andrew would join me. And it became a routine to sit on that porch.

Then one night, 13-year-old Jean-Bertrand Oracius came to sit with us. Slender and barely 5 feet tall, the boy had helped us across a garbage-strewn river earlier that day. He made certain we didn't slip on the wet stones as we stepped around women washing clothes.

For a few moments, Jean-Bertrand sat quietly. Then his tiny voice pierced the air.

"I am hungry," he whispered.

I had some food, but not nearly enough for the dozens of children who would flock to us if they knew. Still, I made a decision. I walked to my room, grabbed an almond-cherry energy bar from my half-open suitcase and returned to the porch. I sat down beside the boy, opened the wrapper and handed him the bar.

"Shhh," I said, and in French, "It's for you."

I told him it was chocolate because I couldn't remember the French words for almond and cherry.

Jean-Bertrand bit into the gooey treat.

"Is it good?" I asked him.

He nodded in the darkness, ate half of it and tucked the rest in his pants pocket — for later.

The next day, Andrew and I went back to work. Sometime late in the afternoon, he walked outside into the back yard to take some photographs of the children. I followed to watch. As I stood there, it began to drizzle. I didn't want to get wet, so I decided to go back inside.

Suddenly, the gray clouds opened and rain began to pour like a waterfall from the sky. Water from a drainpipe on the roof doused the courtyard in heavy sheets. Almost instantly, the children stripped and crowded around the stream, pushing and shoving so they could stand under the shower coming from above.

They laughed and shouted and chased each other, oblivious to the trash and the stench and the deprivation that surround them each day.

In a country where toys are scarce, the rain brought something precious, something fleeting — joy.

And I began to cry.

Haitians expect little from government

Emmanuel Jeremie carries a 2-inch-thick manila folder.

In it are photographs of Haitian children who range from toddlers to teenagers. Some smile into the camera. Others pierce it with sullen eyes.

He knows the details of their lives. Some of their mothers have died. Others were abandoned by their fathers. Then there are those whose parents simply can't afford to care for them anymore.

The Haitian missionary shares their stories when he visits Southwest Florida churches. He asks them to support his Agape Leogane Christian Mission in Haiti, which cares for these children.

"The only chance that Haiti has are the children," says Jeremie, 45.

Southwest Floridians have responded with more than money. Missionaries are teaching, doctoring and donating their time and skills, trying to improve the lives of the impoverished nation's 8 million people.

Stories like Jeremie's are not the exception — they are the norm. Two hundred years after slaves formed the Western Hemisphere's first black republic, more than 80 percent of Haiti's people are poor, half can't read and most won't live to middle age.

Since the rule of iron-fisted dictator François "Papa Doc" Duvalier until now, Haiti's leaders have promised to improve the plight of their people. All have failed miserably, accused of charges from embezzlement to murder.

Political unrest forced Pierrette Faustin's family to flee Haiti when she was a girl. Still, her heart aches for her homeland.

"Dozens of people promise you things, and nothing happens," says Faustin, program director for the Haitian Center of Catholic Charities in Fort Myers.

Haitians endured more broken promises from the country's first democratically elected president, Jean-Bertrand Aristide. A former Catholic priest, Aristide was plagued by allegations of voter fraud and drug trafficking. He was ousted in February. South Africa granted him temporary asylum earlier this month.

Almost four months later, the country remains in crisis. More than 3,000 U.S.-led troops have been stationed there to maintain order. In June, U.N. peacekeepers will try to help with the formation of the new government. Interim prime minister Gerard Latortue, a retired economist, is asking for the international community's help. He wants military backing to disarm insurgents, relief from the country's $100 million budget deficit and money to stimulate the economy, create jobs and improve the most basic of needs.

■

Take, for example, Rue Nationale #3. For years, the Haitian government has talked of paving this road, the country's third main highway and the artery that links the Central Plateau's cities and villages. Still, it remains a potholed stretch of brittle clay that becomes a mud pit when it rains. There are no stop signs. Instead, drivers gingerly steer their pickups through blind turns, honking horns to warn oncoming traffic.

People here, as in the rest of Haiti, have learned not to rely on the government to pave this road or any other — or to provide running water and electricity or to create jobs. They have learned to make do.

They do what their parents and grandparents have done before them: They walk the road to one-room schools or tin-roofed churches. Fathers and sons load donkeys with sugar cane and wood and go to market to sell their cargo to earn a few gourdes, the Haitian currency. Mothers and daughters balance heavy baskets of dirty laundry on their heads on their way to a shallow river, where they sit for hours washing clothes.

Those who flee mountain villages in search of city jobs often find themselves selling bottles of Coke and slices of fried plantains on corners crowded with dogs that sift through garbage. In the teeming neighborhoods of the capital, Port-au-Prince, some of the poor learn to pick their way through those trash mountains for scraps of food or clothing.

Since February's political unrest, not much has changed. Jobs are fewer. Money is more scarce. Food and gas have become even more expensive. Many have placed their faith in Jesus and the people who work in His name, tens of thousands of missionaries — including many from Southwest Florida — who try to supply Haitians with the tools to survive.

While there are no statistics available, Vince Myers, who runs Vince Myers Ministries in Fort Myers, estimates that at least 20,000 missionaries work in Haiti. Because of the proximity, many are Florida-based.

Larger missions have opened schools, clinics and orphanages and use TV to reach American viewers for donations. Others rely on a network of American churches to finance their work and doctors to donate supplies and skills. Still others, who work independently, rely on word-of-mouth for aid.

Myers' ministry donates to missions in several countries, including four groups in Haiti. He sends clothes donated by Southwest Floridians. "And when we get it, we send food," Myers says.

Former Pine Island resident Jim Howard, 56, says the need is overwhelming. "Everybody is moving to Haiti," he says.

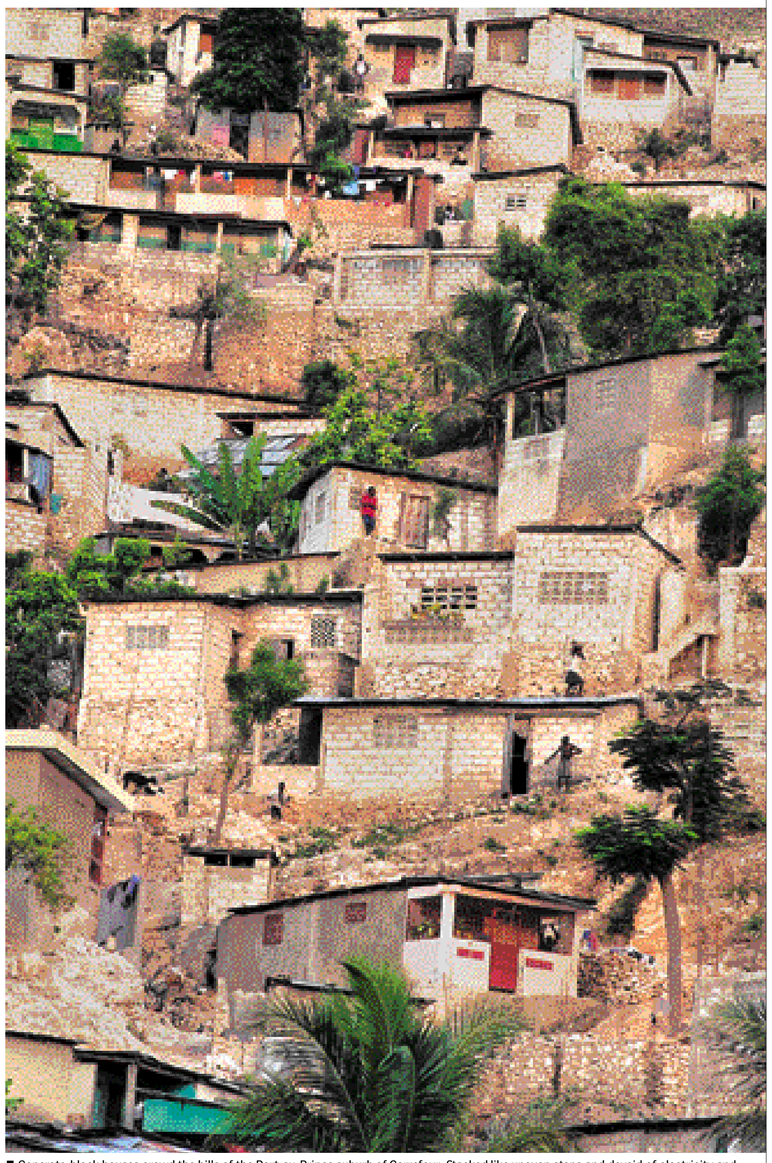
He should know. He and his wife, Barb, spent years working with the Haitian American Friendship Foundation, a Christian-based education mission in the Central Plateau town of Bohoc. A few years ago, the couple branched off, opening their own mission to encourage small-business development.

Last year, they helped Amors Docteur open a print shop in a tin-roofed house the size of a one-car garage. The Howards got a donated copier from a Sanibel church and taught him desktop publishing. He now prints report cards for local schools.

A former social worker, Carol Eisenberg, 31, hopes to have a similar success story to tell someday. That's why she is volunteering at the North Fort Myers-based Educational Concerns for Hunger Organization. "There shouldn't be such disparity in the world," she says.

Faustin agrees. She has a simple dream, really — "for every Haitian to have food on the table, to be able to get up in the morning and say, 'I'm going to work and getting paid at the end of the month.'"

"I hope that will happen," she says.



■ Concrete-block houses crowd the hills of the Port-au-Prince suburb of Carrefour. Stacked like uneven steps and devoid of electricity and running water, homes like these are common in the capital. Haiti is prone to mudslides because of poor construction, deforestation and inadequate roads. Earlier this week, at least 900 people died in mudslides on the Haitian-Dominican Republic border.

TO HELP
- Jim and Barb Howard are missionaries with World Outreach Ministries, which is based in Marietta, Ga.
- **Telephone:** (770) 424-1545
- **Mailing address:** c/o The Howards, Missionary #46, P.O. Box B, Marietta, GA 30061
- **On the Web:** www.worldoutreach.org

HAITIANS IN SOUTHWEST FLORIDA

Many Haitians have come to the United States seeking refuge from political unrest in their homeland. They changed South Florida's ethnic composition, settling in neighborhoods once populated by LatinAmerican immigrants.

As have other immigrant groups, they moved into Miami and Northern cities, settling into Lee County in recent years. They own businesses, work in the service industry and share their views on local radio stations.

Here is a snapshot of Southwest Florida's thriving Haitian community:

■ How many Haitians live here?
A More than 4,500, according to 2000 U.S. Census figures. But Pierrette Faustin, program director for the Haitian Center of Catholic Charities in Fort Myers, suspects the population is twice as large. Many Haitians are reluctant to be counted because of their immigration status, she said. Many in Lee County's Haitian community are newer arrivals, while those who've lived in the United States longer, some since the 1970s, typically come from cities such as Miami, Boston and New York.

■ Where do they live?
A Haitians have settled throughout Lee County from Bonita Springs to Cape Coral. But the heart of Lee County's Haitian community can be found along Fowler Street between Colonial and Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. boulevards in Fort Myers.

■ Why are they here?
A Southwest Florida offers job opportunities and its subtropical climate is similar to Haiti's. Also, the size of the community isn't too small or too large. Once settled, many help relatives by sending money to Haiti. Haitians in the United States sent $810 million to the island in 2002, according to a study by Manuel Orozco of Inter-American Dialogue, a Washington, D.C., think tank.

■ What jobs do they hold?
A Haitian immigrants sometimes work in the agriculture field, picking tomatoes in places such as Immokalee, Faustin said. Some have service jobs in housekeeping. Eventually, many earn degrees or get vocational training for better-paying jobs in health care. Still, others are doctors, nurses and professors.

■ What issues face Lee County's Haitian community?
A Language is a barrier for Creole-speaking Haitian immigrants. They need translators to help with paperwork at social service agencies and schools. Their immigration status can also prevent them from finding jobs.

The number of Creole-speaking students has grown to 1,438. The Lee County School District is considering a Creole language program similar to one for Spanish-speaking parents of school children. The program would keep Creole-speaking parents informed about school news and events.

HAITI'S HOPE



■ A lifetime of working the earth marks Leminis Pierre's hands. Pierre is a farmer at the Haitian American Friendship Foundation and Educational Concerns for Hunger Organization. ECHO, based in North Fort Myers, runs a farm on a compound owned by HAFF, a Christian-based mission in Bohoc, Haiti. ECHO uses crops and farming techniques to fight hunger in developing countries.

ECHO workers plant seeds of knowledge

Carol Eisenberg was a New York City social worker.

She didn't know a thing about plants.

Now, the 31-year-old tries to grow mushrooms in large plastic bags. Sometimes, she doesn't use soil.

She hopes her experiments will help feed people in Haiti. Twenty-three percent of its population suffers from chronic malnutrition, according to the United Nations World Food Programme. To put it in human terms — one in three Haitian children is malnourished.

A year ago, Eisenberg's faith in God and desire to make a difference brought her to a 44-acre compound off Durrance Road in North Fort Myers. There, Educational Concerns for Hunger Organization uses science to fight hunger in Haiti and other developing countries. The nonprofit Christian group attracts people such as Eisenberg who spend their days testing everything from papayas to tomatoes.

Will a specific kind of banana, called Goldfinger, thrive in Haiti's 1,200-foot mountains during a dry April? Does the soil contain enough nitrogen to produce cabbage? If not, is there some other fast-growing vegetable that farmers can quickly plant and pick?

ECHO's farm is divided into sections similar to the climates of struggling countries. Sprinklers douse the ground and mimic a rain forest in Central America. Lettuce-filled discarded tires atop tin-roof shanties prove container gardening can work in Port-au-Prince, where shacks are stacked up against barren, rocky hillsides.

Meanwhile, the monsoons that plague India are simulated in another area — bearing the *Moringa stenopetala*, a broad tree with delicate green leaves. A native of Ethiopia, the moringa grows in the tropics. Except for the wood, all of it is edible.

"It's one of our multipurpose trees," Eisenberg says.

She and the other ECHO workers and volunteers observe plants' growth patterns like first-time mothers.

"Jakfruit planted September 2001," reads a handwritten label staked next to a tall tree with spiky green fruits.

"Bell Carambola planted June 2003," reads another label. No yellow star fruit on this tree yet.

If a crop thrives here, it could be introduced to a farmer in Bohoc, a town of rugged clay roads and sugar cane fields tucked in the mountains of Haiti's Central Plateau. This is where ECHO runs a small farm. If a crop succeeds for one farmer, another may be prompted to grow it. And then, they can feed their children.

"Hunger touches everything," Eisenberg explains.

■

When Tim Motis came to interview for a job at ECHO, he and his wife, Paige, hoped they would settle in Southwest Florida for some time. They wanted to live in a place where he could apply his knowledge of plants and she could teach English.

Martin Price, ECHO's executive director, wanted someone to recharge the farm it operates in Haiti with the Haitian American Friendship Foundation, another Christian-based mission that focuses on education. But not many people could live in one of the farm's tin-roofed cottages, which have no running water or air conditioning. The work would be difficult because Haitian farmers don't have tractors, irrigation or fertilizer. The job would call for someone with the patience to farm the way Americans did 200 years ago — the way most Haitians still do — digging with shovels, planting with their hands and watering with buckets.

Price believed Tim, 35, and Paige, 29, were perfect for the assignment. They could mentor and supervise Eisenberg and the other ECHO workers who came to help for three months at a time.

In January, the Motises moved to Haiti, where they live in a two-bedroom house with no bathroom. At night, they use mosquito netting over the bed. But that doesn't keep pests — including rats — from getting into the house. One night, a moth flew in Paige Motis' ear and her husband had to fish it out.

"That was the night I thought Paige wanted to leave Haiti," Tim Motis jokes.

"Oh, yeah, it's been an adventure," she says.

Working for ECHO in Haiti has been worthwhile.

"You have to learn about different crops," Tim Motis says. "I'm finding that I have to completely re-educate myself."

ECHO workers plant winged beans, onions and fruit trees to see what will grow well. Once he's gathered details on a thriving crop, Tim Motis must encourage local farmers to slowly test the plant on their lands. It's a delicate situation, he says. "If you pass out a lot of seed and it fails, your reputation goes downhill pretty fast."

So for now, they pass out young avocado trees to students. The hope is that the trees are planted by the children's parents. With some luck, good weather and a little care, they might grow and bear fruit and feed families.

■ Carol Eisenberg, an ECHO intern, harvests mushrooms at ECHO's North Fort Myers farm. She plans to study the crop while she works at ECHO's farm in Haiti.

TO HELP

■ Educational Concerns for Hunger Organization is based in North Fort Myers. Its mission is to use science and technology to help farmers in developing countries grow nutritious crops to fight hunger. It also has a contributions program, gardening classes and gift shop and offers tours of its farm.
■ **Telephone:** 543-3246
■ **Address:** 17391 Durrance Road, North Fort Myers, FL 33917
■ **Web site:** www.echonet.org



■ Joseph Muni tills land in Bohoc, Haiti. ECHO workers try to help farmers such as Muni grow crops that will thrive and feed families. Many of Haiti's people suffer from hunger.

HAITI'S HOPE

Cape family answers call to strange land

Ten years ago, Greg and Barb Van Schoyck decided to move to a country where they couldn't speak the language, didn't know the culture and wouldn't look like anyone who lived there.

While poverty forced families to risk their lives on rickety boats bound for America, the Cape Coral couple took their children in the opposite direction — to Haiti.

The Van Schoycks and their daughter, Gabi, now 18, and their son, Zach, now 16, settled in the mountain village of Bohoc.

According to the couple, God called them to a mission that is as central to Haitians as the churches and schools there.

Since then, the Van Schoycks and their children have learned the language, adopted the culture and formed bonds with people they've come to call friends.

"It's really my home," Gabi explains.

This is the Haitian American Friendship Foundation, a 40-acre compound of mango and mahogany trees so dense their canopies obscure the stars. In a place where people see education as a passport out of poverty, HAFF runs Bohoc's only high school.

Wearing gray shirts and blue skirts and pants, about 225 students in their teens to mid-20s line up each morning in a field. They are surrounded by white cottages with rusty roofs. The students separate by grade, walk inside their classroom and sit on wooden benches.

The students lower their heads and pray. Then, they open thin composition books, uncap their pens and begin taking notes as their teacher lectures on the works of Molière, Descartes and other French writers.

In another building, Barb teaches students verb tenses in English. Across the way, a teacher not much older than his students talks about how plants convert sunlight into energy.

"It's a benediction from God," math teacher Thony Deshommes says of the school.

■

The Van Schoycks' journey to HAFF began in 1986 when Barb was pregnant with Gabi. That's when she and Greg wanted to get closer to God. Through friends, they found Evangelical Presbyterian Church of Cape Coral. In April 1992, Barb joined church members traveling to the Haitian mission. She found an organization that taught students and helped the poor.

Today, the mission offers medical care, which is usually provided by Telius Berçon, a nurse who gives prenatal exams and physicals. Another program teaches hygiene and AIDS prevention. AIDS afflicts 480,000 people, 6 percent of Haiti's 8 million population, according to the CIA World Factbook.

In addition, the mission offers agricultural training on its farm, operated jointly with the Educational Concerns for Hunger Organization of North Fort Myers. This is important in a country where more than 80 percent of the population lives in poverty.

A freelance writer for various Southwest Florida publications, Barb was supposed to report on her experiences. Instead, she became part of the story.

She wanted to return. Six months later, she did — with Greg. This time, she volunteered to teach English classes. That's when she realized God was calling her to Haiti.

"I can remember falling in love with the students," the 50-year-old Kentucky native says. "There's just something about these young people that was so precious to me."

A Cape Coral jewelry store manager, Greg wasn't as certain as his wife. He would have to give up his job and their four-bedroom home for a cottage with no running water or air conditioning.

He had serious concerns: Would Haiti be a good place to raise children? Could they learn Creole? Would they really help people who needed so much?

They prayed for an answer. It came on Memorial Day 1993.

Joining church friends, the Van Schoycks took Zach, then 5, and Gabi to Sanibel's Lighthouse Park Beach for the day. After lunch, Zach went into the water. By the time he came out, he became confused by the shifting tide — and he walked away from the group.

The couple and their friends searched for the boy for hours, fearful that he might have drowned. The police were called and boaters and beachgoers were asked to join the search. Eventually, someone found the frightened dark-haired boy looking for his parents.

"I think it was God's way of saying, 'Hey, it's going to be OK. You can lose your kids in Fort Myers. You can lose your kids in Haiti. It's going to be OK,'" Greg says.

■

At 5:30 a.m., barking dogs and crowing roosters join in chorus. The sky transforms from charcoal black to dusty pink as the sun rises over the mountains.

Along a dirt road known as Rue Nationale #3, Haiti's third main highway, women sit on the ground surrounded by plastic tubs of water. Grease-splattered pots, plastic cups and metal bowls clank as the women wash, rinse and stack them to one side.

Other women sit in tiny wooden chairs and gossip at the side of the road. They spread white sheets like picnic blankets over the ground to display the fiery plum tomatoes, deep green bananas and pale cabbage heads from their gardens.

Across the way, ECHO workers Vicki Orrostieta, 26, and Jolie Goldenetz, 24, are out on the morning run, passing the cluster of classrooms and following the worn grassy path deeper into the compound. Connie Curilla, a Pennsylvania native who joined HAFF 18 years ago, walks into the kitchen and chastises Morgan, a gray tabby, for knocking over a bottle. Still, the cat coils around her feet as she prepares breakfast, a bowl of last night's pasta and tuna.

Curilla, 44, places the bowl of food on the windowsill for the cat. Then she walks to the open-air stall that adjoins the pantry and picks up a 5-gallon bucket. She carries it to the tall blue drum by her bedroom and scoops out water to take back to the shower — for her sponge bath.

In the kitchen next door, Barb Van Schoyck uses a gas flame to brew Haitian coffee in a metal coffeepot and prepares a breakfast of her homemade mango muffins for Greg, Gabi and Zach. They join hands, bow their heads and thank God for another day.

Barb eventually heads off to her classroom while Greg tours the grounds to see about the chores. At 10 a.m., Zach walks a few yards to Herb Mitchell's place, which looks like every other house at the HAFF compound. The only difference is the wooden desk in a corner of the living room, which is stacked with physics and chemistry textbooks.

Lying on the pile is his brown mesh ball cap. "Working for the LORD on Earth don't pay much. But his retirement plan is out of this world!" the bold white letters read.

A Harvard graduate who studied computers in their infancy in the 1930s and worked for NASA, the 90-year-old Cape Coral resident has traveled the world. Four years ago, Mitchell joined a church group visiting HAFF. He returned last year after he read that Barb was searching for a volunteer to teach physics and chemistry to Zach and his sister. A widower, he offered his services, moving to Haiti in September.

"It gives me something to do, to put my teeth into," he says.

■



■ Seven-month-old Samyel Senlwi cries while Barb Van Schoyck adds him to a milk program offered by the Haitian American Friendship Foundation to children who are malnourished. Van Schoyck says Samyel is regaining his strength.

When Barb Van Schoyck returns at lunchtime, two young women wait under a shade tree across from her house. One of them cradles a 7-month-old boy, Samyel Senlwi, whose thin face is streaked with tears. His mother has stopped producing milk, and she couldn't feed her child. Could Barb help?

You get used to death in a country where 76 out of every 1,000 newborns die and the average life expectancy is 51. Barb has attended more than 30 funerals in 10 years. She has seen babies die from malnutrition to malaria — all preventable with the right medicine and enough money.

She has started a milk program. Children — and sometimes their mothers if they are weak — are fattened with a milk powder dissolved in water. Villagers learn to enroll by word-of-mouth. Every day, except Sunday, they come for the milk, called Alaska Instant, although it's made in Holland. With about 40 children to feed, the Van Schoycks can go through one 5-gallon can a day. It yields many bottles of milk. Once healthy, a child is taken off the program to make room for another sick child. There's always another sick child.

Barb looks at Samyel and recognizes the signs. He is underweight and underdeveloped. Barb adds another sick child to the list.

■

The Van Schoycks still miss some of the amenities of Southwest Florida — air conditioning, for one.

"I miss Thai food," Gabi says.

Her father agrees: "I think Siam Hut in Cape Coral has the best (coconut soup)."

Because their favorite restaurant is a 90-minute plane ride and 2½-hour drive away, the family has filled the craving for home in other ways. Almost every Friday, Greg fires up the electric generator. Zach wanders in with Fabneau Jean, whom he has known since he was 6. Everyone settles at the table, sitting on the wooden chairs that Greg has embellished with the tropical colors typical of Matlacha galleries. They say a prayer of thanks and then eat popcorn and chocolate-chip muffins, baked by Barb, as Zach and Fabneau chatter in Creole.

TO HELP

■ The Haitian American Friendship Foundation was formed in the 1970s in Haiti's Central Plateau. It offers several programs, including a secondary school, primary school teacher training, medical and dental clinics, and Bible study.
■ **Telephone:** 543-1734
■ **Addresses:**
■ *For contributions:* HAFF, P.O. Box 3421, North Fort Myers, FL 33918
■ *To write to missionaries:* HAFF, c/o missionary's name, P.O. Box 24638-HAFF, West Palm Beach, FL 33416
■ **On the Web:** www.haff.org

Barb and Gabi talk about their day, which involved hiking an hour through the rocky hills to lead a Bible study class in a little village. They had worried that gray clouds would keep people away. But as they came closer to their destination, people joined them.

The group stopped in front of the Divine Hand of Jesus Christ Church, a metal-roofed building set on concrete blocks. There are no doors or windows, just holes that churchgoers climbed through to listen to Barb talk about peace.

In a country plagued by violence, the Van Schoycks find peace in these Friday nights. After dinner, Gabi sprawls out on a woven rug in the small living room. Curilla, ECHO horticulturist Tim Motis and his wife, Paige, and other friends stop by. They settle in to watch TV shows friends in Cape Coral have taped for them — the mother-daughter comedy of "The Gilmore Girls" and the military drama "JAG." But it's the latest plot twists in "Alias" that make them gasp.

■

The Toyota Land Cruiser idles in front of the Van Schoycks' house. Years of trudging muddy roads have freckled its white body with orange rust. It isn't pretty, but it runs.

It's Saturday, market day — an affair that, as Barb describes, "is a little different than running to Publix."

One of Zach's friends, Jeremy Israel, a 24-year-old HAFF student, sits in the back, talking into one of the walkie-talkies Zach's grandmother gave him for his birthday in March. Zach drives the bumpy route, clutching the large steering wheel as he guides the Land Cruiser around potholes.

Hundreds of people and their farm animals crowd the road. Women balance baskets of papayas, tomatoes and eggplants on their heads. Men load bundles of wood, 100-pound bags of rice and even larger sacks of coal on the backs of their bony donkeys and lead the animals away. Everyone is headed to the market in Pignon, about six miles up the road.

Neighbor Elmeus Valcourt hitches a ride. His dark skin glistens in the sunlight that shines through the dusty windshield. He isn't certain of his age but knows that he was born during President Louis Borno's administration in the 1920s. "In those days, things weren't expensive. The country ran well," he says.

The brim of Valcourt's straw hat is turned up like a fedora and he must use a belt to keep his gray trousers in place. In his stubby fingers, he clutches a knobby cane and a megaphone. Barely 5 feet, he seems lost sitting between the 6-foot-plus American and his son.

■ Continued on page 6

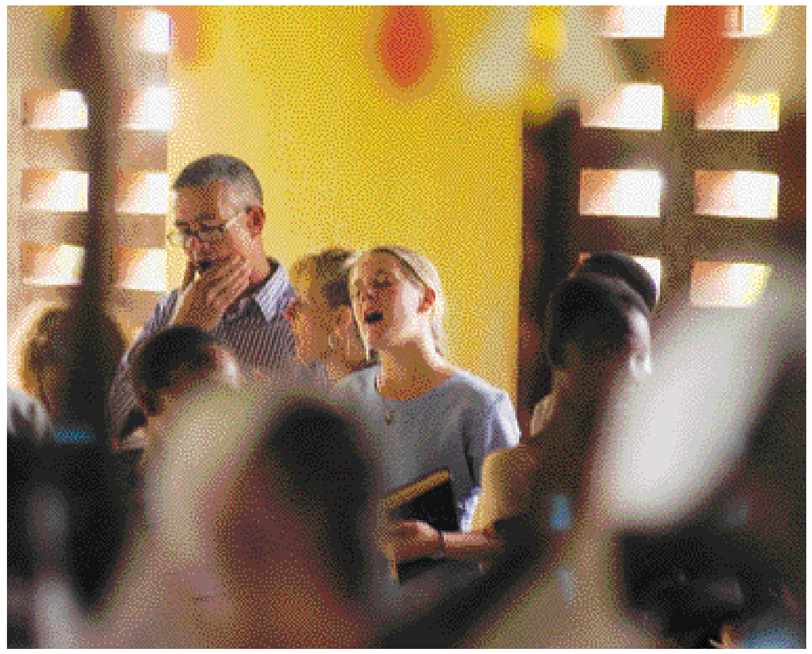
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HAITI'S HOPE



■ **ABOVE:** Nicknamed "The Evangelist," Elmeus Valcourt preaches to children and passersby while he sits in a Toyota Land Cruiser. The Van Schoycks, a missionary family from Cape Coral, give Valcourt a ride to the town of Pignon, where he preaches and they shop. Valcourt travels from village to village with a megaphone he uses to broadcast his religious messages.

■ **BELOW:** The Van Schoycks, from left, Greg, Barb and Gabi, attend a Sunday service at Eglise Baptist Maranatha de Bohoc. Greg and Barb's son Zach, 16, plays the guitar and drums in the church band.



■ Continued from page 5

Thirty minutes later, Zach drives the Land Cruiser onto the narrow, crowded streets of Pignon. The pungent scents of rotting food, animal waste and charcoal from roadside stands mix in the air. Pigs and puppies with protruding ribs wander the streets, sniffing through the trash heaped on corners.

Zach stops across the street from a small house to let Gabi — and two children who have been sitting with her in the back seat — climb out of the Toyota. Gabi walks toward the house with the youngsters, greeting the homeowner on the porch.

"*Bonjour, madame*," Gabi pulls up a bedsheet that serves as a door to a room inside the house where 20 girls sit on makeshift benches. A green chalkboard is propped on a wall. With sunlight beaming through a narrow window, Gabi begins her lesson.

"What is a dog?" she asks in English.

"*Chien*," they reply in French.

Meanwhile, Zach heads to the market, parking near a rundown hospital with barred doors. He and his parents divide their money. They have much to buy — eggs, rice, tomatoes, onions, cabbage — and little time. The men head off together as Barb begins her hunt.

Stalls selling pinto beans, cornmeal and bags of rice are so tight that Barb and thousands of other shoppers have to step over the food or be pushed by the crowd. Flies swarm around the produce and hover over the cuts of unwrapped chicken and meat. There is no refrigeration.

Children follow Barb, shouting over the haggling between vendors and shoppers.

"Black sacks, soap to wash," a little girl bellows, showing off her sticks of soap. A boy with her holds black plastic bags.

Barb finds a bagful of tomatoes for 30 gourdes, about $3.

About an hour later, she meets her family across the street from the office where Greg pays taxes on HAFF's employees. Valcourt sits in the front seat, waiting to return home. The old man rolls down the passenger window, pulls out his megaphone and presses a button.

"Whatever you are, Adventist, Catholic ... ask God for forgiveness," he shouts as people walk by him.

"When he's got that megaphone, he goes to town," Barb says.

■

The Van Schoycks rely on faith to help them in a country that teeters on chaos.

"I can't imagine coming here and not being a Christian because it's a frightening place," says Greg, 51.

He should know. He and his family have lived through it.

On Feb. 5, rebels in the coastal city of Gonaives launched a coup against embattled President Jean-Bertrand Aristide. More anti-Aristide groups surfaced in other cities and towns. The missionaries' family and friends expressed concern. They'd heard news reports about the unrest in Haiti and sent e-mails. Please leave, they implored.

But nestled between the towns of Pignon and Hinche, the missionaries felt safe. Then, one day, HAFF employee Elizert Vilbon hopped on a motorcycle and drove to Hinche to run some errands. As he passed the Hinche police station, gunshots killed the police chief and two guards.

Vilbon told everyone what he'd witnessed.

That's when they all realized this coup was different — it was spreading from city to city like wildfire. Disenchanted with Aristide, many former soldiers had taken up the cause. Police abandoned northern Haiti. Buildings were burned. Roads were blocked. Prices soared.

In Cap-Haitien, Haiti's second-largest city, gas was selling for $10 a gallon. Aristide vowed to remain in office, and the Haitian people feared civil war.

The U.S. Embassy issued warnings. On Feb. 11, non-emergency embassy employees were asked to leave. On Feb. 21, Americans were told to leave immediately. Three days later, after much prayer, the Van Schoycks and the other missionaries left.

On Feb. 29, Aristide was forced out of office. A U.S.-led international force of 3,600 troops landed in Haiti and order was restored — but only after 300 people were killed.

On March 18, the Van Schoycks returned. Tim and Paige Motis joined them a few weeks later.

No one questioned why they left. "They understood," Greg says.

And no one questions why they returned.

■

The violence has left a rough wake. HAFF needs about $130,000 to operate this year, but the money is harder to come by. There are fewer visitors this year, meaning fewer jobs. And many volunteers have canceled trips because of the country's instability.

Diranot Previlus usually works as an assistant to West Virginia dentist Jerry Pennington, who visits HAFF each year. Without the job, Previlus has no way to feed his wife and three children. "I'm having a difficult time," Previlus says.

He planned to walk 30 minutes to a friend's house in a neighboring town to ask for help. He isn't bitter or angry, though.

"God is my force," Previlus says. "When God is in my life ... I still have hope."

■

If hope is measured by a people's love for God, then Haiti still has much.

In the slums of Port-au-Prince, women who wash their clothes in polluted rivers sing God's praises.

"*Mèsi, Jezu. Mèsi*," they say in Creole. "Thank you, Jesus. Thank you."

High atop a mountain, orphans in tin-roof shacks sing joyfully in the night's darkness.

"*Jezu es roi*," they sing. "Jesus is king."

In the country, where children sit on uneven benches to recite letters scrawled on cardboard, they thank him for their school.

"Hallelujah," they say. "Hallelujah."

Like the rest of Haiti, Sunday in Bohoc is dedicated to God.

Women wear their best dresses and arrange their hair in braids, pinning on pieces of white lace as a sign of respect for His house.



■ **ABOVE:** Barb Van Schoyck listens to Ismanette Louis talk about the pain in her legs while Louis' child, Ines, 3, plays with a knife. Van Schoyck plans to find Louis a walker or cane so she can walk through the dirt paths of her remote village more easily.

■ **RIGHT:** Greg Van Schoyck helps Deces Charles with a basket of food that weighs at least 35 pounds. At times, Charles walks five to seven miles with the basket atop her head after shopping at the Pignon market.





■ Greg Van Schoyck drops off Elmeus Valcourt at his home after spending a Saturday morning in the nearby town of Pignon. Driving along Rue Nationale #3, the country's third main highway, Van Schoyck stops to speak with a friend.



■ Elmeus Valcourt walks home after Sunday morning services at Eglise Baptist Maranatha de Bohoc, a church near the Haitian American Friendship Foundation.

Men don dress shirts, ties and perfectly pressed pants. Their shoes shine like mirrors in the sun.

Even the children come in clothes that are pressed and clean — bearing no trace of the dusty miles they walked to attend. Clutching their Bibles, they enter Eglise Baptist Maranatha de Bohoc with reverence. Some of the women tiptoe on the concrete floor, so their high heels don't interrupt the service.

The pulpit is festooned with pink and yellow plastic flowers. A loudspeaker set too high emits tinny sounds as the church band plays. The congregation sings fervently, the voices reverberating from the rafters. They sway, raising their hands as if they were trying to touch God.

Heaven came down and glory filled my soul
When at the cross the Savior made me whole
My sins were washed away
And my nights were turned to day
Heaven came down and glory filled
my soul ...

Greg, Barb and Gabi sit at the back of the church — Zach plays with the band. When the song is over, people bow their heads to pray.

"When you walk right with God, blessings will fall upon you with abundance," the pastor says.

When the two-hour service ends, the Van Schoycks stream out of the church with the other worshippers.

For a few minutes, they take the time to laugh and talk with friends. Then, they stroll down the rocky road together — ready for another week.

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HAITI'S HOPE

Love A Child looks after physical needs

Nicole Jean watched the six white women walk toward her thatch-roofed hut.

One woman wheeled a folded chair over the rocky path that leads to her village in Fond Parisien on Haiti's arid eastern edge. They walked through mud and over raw sewage and dirty water that had settled in puddles near her home. The rest carried plastic buckets filled with water or bottles, tubes and small plastic bags.

These *blancs*, as Haitians call whites, caused a stir in a place where the most exciting part of the day is watching trucks race on the highway that severs the village. Naked boys and girls in pigtails swarmed the foreigners as if they had come bearing Christmas presents.

"*Blancs, blancs* give me one dolla," some of the children demanded, mustering the few English words they knew.

Jean smiled. She knew two of the women — the blonde who dabbed perspiration from her cheeks and the brunette whose eyeglasses hung from a chain around her neck.

Sitting on the floor of her doorway, she didn't stand to receive her guests. The 43-year-old mother of seven had lost all movement in her legs when donkeys trampled her. With no feeling below her waist, she couldn't tell whether she'd developed new sores on her feet and backside. She didn't know whether the already-festering wounds had healed.

There are no doctors in this village where the sun sears rugged hills of cactus and bakes the clay earth until it cracks like shattered china. Sherry Burnette, Sally Heier and the other women had driven from the sprawling Love A Child orphanage on a medical mission — to clean Jean's wounds and share words of encouragement.

Burnette, Heier and two others crammed into Jean's sweltering mud-and-stone hut, raised her onto a bed and lifted her shirt. They began examining her legs and bare buttocks. Children crowded in the doorway and peered through the windows.

The sore on Jean's backside was healing. The opening was much smaller than weeks earlier when it was bigger than a fist.

But Jean's feet were swollen from dragging them on the ground while being pushed around the village in an old wheelchair.

Heier, a Lee County school nurse, couldn't feel a pulse on Jean's left ankle. No blood was flowing to her foot. Jean's small toe would fall off in a day or two.

She needed to go to a hospital in Port-au-Prince, about an hour's drive away. But until Burnette could arrange that, Betadine antiseptic, topical antibiotics and gauze would have to do.

Jean did not protest during the examination. Instead, she flashed a smile, hugged Heier and asked her for the bottle tucked in a pocket of her scrubs.

After Heier handed the water to Jean, she explained that patients in Southwest Florida were not likely to be so accommodating. But here, Heier received reassurances from Jean.

"*Piti, piti, wazo fe nich li*," she said in Creole, recalling a proverb that Haitians often repeat.

"Little by little, the bird builds its nest."

When Heier encounters people like Jean, she is certain of her decision.

In June, Heier will quit her job. She and her 75-year-old husband, Bob, will leave their three-bedroom house, located next door to her daughter's Lehigh Acres home. The couple will move about 1,000 miles away to live in a 25-foot-by-25-foot house on Love A Child's new compound in Fond Parisien.

"I'm excited. I can't wait," said Sally Heier, 55. "Finally, I'm doing something where no matter what, you had a great day. A great day."

She wants to use her medical skills for more than treating headaches, bandaging knees and writing passes for teenagers who are more interested in cutting class.

Haiti is the kind of place where the Heiers can make a difference. Her husband agreed. The pastor put his other talents to use. He has sorted through shipments of medicine, painted mission buildings and done whatever is needed.

"That's why we go — to do more, to do anything," Bob Heier said.

The Heiers' lives changed forever one evening when they turned on the TV and saw Burnette and her husband, Bobby, on the screen.

The couple told of the Naples-based Love A Child Christian ministry they formed in 1985. They shared the stories of the Haitian people — children with open sores; toddlers with bloated bellies and sullen eyes; new mothers so undernourished that they'd stopped producing milk for their own babies.



■ Sally Heier, a Lehigh Acres nurse, treats Nicole Jean's leg during a visit to her home in Fond Parisien. Heier and her husband plan to move to Haiti this summer to volunteer with Love A Child, a Christian mission based in Naples. Heier will help run clinics in remote villages. "Finally, I'm doing something where no matter what, you had a great day," she says.



■ Guests visit a new orphanage run by the Naples-based Love A Child mission. Set to open in July, the orphanage will be home to about 100 children in Fond Parisien.

During the national television program, the Burnettes explained that the Haitian people needed food. They needed medicine. In fact, they needed everything. They explained that their mission was feeding more than 1,500 Haitian children, housing and educating orphaned youngsters and treating the sick in the villages around the mission.

"You couldn't turn it off," Sally Heier said of the program.

She called the 800 number that flashed on the screen and donated money. But that wasn't enough. Last July, she went to Haiti on the first of many trips. Each one has cost between $1,000 and $1,500 for air fare, supplies and other expenses.

Sally Heier was stunned by what she found: children who'd never used a bathroom, women who didn't know what a stove is. "There are these kids who don't even have a drink of water when they get up," she said.

Still, it was more than what Bobby Burnette found on his first visit in the 1970s. The Orlando native, whose Creole is soaked in an Old Florida drawl, made more than 450 mission trips before he and his wife moved there in 1991.

"I've been all over the world, but I've never seen a place like Haiti," Bobby Burnette said.

Since then, the Burnettes have built a $12 million budget, which they use to construct orphanages and organize food programs and medical clinics. In July, Love A Child will open a two-story, 21,500-square-foot orphanage in Fond Parisien. The facility will come complete with electricity, running water, large dormitories and a lush atrium.

Overlooking a brackish lake, mountains and fields of cactus and papaya, the creamy yellow building that sits on 200 acres will be home to about 100 children. The Burnettes hope to add 33 more buildings — including a vocational school — on the property, which was donated by a Haitian couple now living in Winter Park.

It's a minor miracle, according to Donna Bryce, who co-founded Feed A Child — a Haitian mission with a self-explanatory goal. Bryce knows what it takes to do what the Burnettes have done in a country wracked by violence and government instability.

"It's a land of mass confusion," she said.

So outsiders like Bryce, the Burnettes and the Heiers bring some hope. "You can't go anywhere that they don't need you," Sally Heier said.

TO HELP

■ Love A Child, a Naples-based nonprofit Christian organization, helps feed and educate children, and offers medical treatment to poor Haitians.
■ **Telephone:** (239) 261-9799
■ **Mailing address:** P.O. Box 11000, Naples, FL 34101-1000
■ **On the Web:** www.loveachild.com
■ **On TV:** 8:30 p.m. Sundays and 8 p.m. Tuesdays on WRXY TV 49 (check cable listings for channels)



■ Nicole Jean, right, hugs Sherry Burnette, co-founder of the Naples-based Love A Child mission, after Burnette gave her a wheelchair. Paralyzed, Jean struggles to move around the dirt paths of her village in Fond Parisien in southeastern Haiti.

HAITI'S HOPE



■ With help from his older brother, a boy who lives at the Good Samaritan Orphanage Salem Haiti takes a bath before going to school. The orphanage is home to almost 100 children. Most of them bathe by pouring buckets of cold water over themselves.

Medical mission splits pastor, family

Down a quiet, narrow road in south Fort Myers, a green-and-gray mobile home sits near a half-built gated community. On its emerald lawn is a metal pole where a red-and-deep-blue flag flutters in the breeze.

The flag's white square center features the Haitian coat of arms — two cannons and a palm tree. Underneath is a French phrase: *"L'Union Fait La Force,"* "In Union There Is Strength."



BERNADETTE JOSEPH



CALEB JOSEPH

For Haiti and the Josephs, the family who live on Timothy Lane, unity has been elusive.

The family is divided by hundreds of miles of land and sea. Georges Joseph, a physician and pastor, spends most of his time in his homeland. About every three months, he returns to visit his youngest son, Caleb, and his wife, Bernadette.

Five years ago, Georges Joseph sent his son, then 14, to Southwest Florida so the boy could have a better life.

■

While the family was not poor by Haitian standards, they weren't sheltered from the deprivation that plagues the land. The pastor owns a home in a Port-au-Prince suburb, but his neighbors live in sand-colored shanties that scale scarred hillsides.

Haiti is a mere 90-minute plane trip from Miami, but it may as well be a trip to Mars. In its 200 years of independence from France, Haiti has endured dictators, such as François "Papa Doc" Duvalier and his son, Jean-Claude "Baby Doc" Duvalier, who entertained at the presidential palace while their people lived in wood shanties blocks away.

The constant instability in Haiti, the Western Hemisphere's poorest nation, saps the country of jobs, money and food. Slightly more than half of its 8 million people cannot read and write. About 76 of every 1,000 babies die at birth. And the average life span is 51.6 years, according to statistics from the CIA World Factbook.

"Everything over there is so rough," Caleb Joseph said.

When political turmoil grips Haiti, as in February when rebels ousted former President Jean-Bertrand Aristide, people shut their businesses, few venture onto the streets and schools can close for months. Students fall behind, which explains why 20-year-olds sit in the same class with pupils five years their junior.

When schools reopen, learning remains a challenge. In an elementary school Georges Joseph runs near Port-au-Prince, for example, 60 fifth- and sixth-graders sit on bowed wooden benches. They have no texts and take notes in dog-eared composition books, as their teachers write vocabulary words on a torn piece of cardboard.

The teachers are paid $30 a month.

"It isn't enough, but they accept it," Georges Joseph said.

■

So the distance between Port-au-Prince and south Fort Myers is the price Caleb Joseph pays for his dream of becoming a surgeon.

Caleb has adapted easily to the move, thanks to his youth and his stepmother, Bernadette Joseph, a retired teacher. She introduced him to famous Americans such as Thomas Jefferson and helped him improve his English.

Today, he attends Edison Community College. He sits in an air-conditioned calculus class with about 15 students, most of them white. The differences in culture and color don't bother him.

"I don't see people different. It's just not my mentality," he explained.

At home in south Fort Myers, he surfs the Web on his own computer without worrying about blackouts. He visits movies.com and checks e-mails from friends in Haiti. He doesn't talk to them about his homeland because his life is different now. He isn't concerned about political unrest or school closings or government-sanctioned gangs that threaten you if you speak out. Instead, when they write once a month, the boys share the kind of jokes that make teenagers laugh.

When Caleb lived in Haiti, sometimes his father would drive him three hours west to visit a mountain village called Bonody. At the base of the mountain, they would begin a two-hour hike up a rocky path, the father leading the way on a horse brought down by a villager. Strapped to its side would be bags filled with antibiotics, vitamins and other medical supplies.

Once they reached the town, Caleb would watch his father press his smooth hands on a child's swollen belly, thumping it like a melon, to see if the stomach was bloated from gas or parasites or malnutrition. The village women would prepare large plates of rice and pinto beans. Their sons would shimmy up coconut trees, pluck the fruit and whack it open on the ground with machetes so the father and son could quench their thirst.

Caleb misses those days and the people who opened their homes — and hearts — to him. But now he is content with the weekly telephone calls to his father and the occasional visit.

"I don't have any intention of going back," he said.

■

Large suitcases filled with clothes, bags of lollipops and big bottles of antibiotics and generic aspirin are among the things stacked from the living room to the back porch of Bernadette Joseph's south Fort Myers home.

The clutter makes the 70-year-old woman smile. The blue jeans and summer skirts will clothe the children who live in the orphanages that her husband, Georges Joseph, runs in Haiti. He will use the aspirin and antibiotics to treat his patients, many of whom live in isolated mountain towns.

"People are always thinking of us," said Bernadette Joseph.

In Lee County, the donations come from St. Hilary's Episcopal Church, Blessed Pope John XXIII Catholic Church and The Salvation Army.

In Greeneville, Tenn., Sunday school classes at Faith Temple — a church that has heard of the pastor's ministry — collect a few hundred dollars each month to help pay the $150 needed to buy sacks of rice. The 100-pound bags feed the 97 children who live in the orphanage her husband operates near Port-au-Prince.

Each morning, the children eat bulgur, a dull cracked wheat. When they return from school, they eat beans and rice. Nightly, they snack on bread, mangoes and candy. Before the Tennessee donations, "those children were sharing a plate and eating one meal a day," Bernadette Joseph said.

■ Continued on page 10

TO HELP

Good Samaritan Orphanage Salem Haiti has schools and orphanages throughout Haiti.
■ **Telephone:** 454-2581
■ **Mailing address:** Bread of Life Ministries, 16581 McGregor Blvd., Fort Myers, FL 33908

Vince Myers Ministries collects clothing and other items for mission groups in several countries. It also runs a Bible college and trains people to do ministry work.
■ **Telephone:** 332-1217
■ **Mailing address:** P.O. Box 50763, Fort Myers, FL 33994-0763
■ **On the Web:** vincemyersmin.home.comcast.net



■ Boys at the Good Samaritan Orphanage Salem Haiti spend the night with 19 other children in a small room. Some sleep on pieces of carpeting under beds. Pastor Georges Joseph has 97 children, including relatives, living in an orphanage he operates from his house near Port-au-Prince. He is building more dormitories about a quarter of a mile from his house near a church and school he founded, but he says it's difficult to make room for all the children. "Every day ... people ask me to receive some (of their) kids because they can't feed them."

HAITI'S HOPE



■ A horse carries Georges Joseph, a physician and pastor, up a mountain to a small school and church in the village of Bonody. He brings medicine and other supplies on his monthly trips to visit children in an orphanage and school he operates there. With the nearest hospital hours away, Joseph also treats villagers.

■ Continued from page 9

Georges Joseph met Bernadette about 10 years ago through a mutual friend who asked Bernadette to drive him around during a visit to Southwest Florida. The New York transplant took him to Sanibel Island to see the beaches, the alligators and the strangler fig trees.

"He was a man of God," she said.

Sometime afterward, one of Joseph's five children, Alexandra, then 19, wrote and asked if she could visit. Bernadette agreed, taking her to the movies, shopping and sightseeing. Bernadette became a mother figure to the girl, whose own mother, Louisiane, had died of cancer in 1998. Eventually, Bernadette invited Alexandra to stay with her permanently so the girl could attend Edison Community College. Then Bernadette made a similar offer to one of Joseph's sons — Georges Junior. Caleb followed soon after.

Divorced for many years and the mother of five children of her own, Bernadette had never considered remarrying — but then, "the Lord spoke to my heart," she said.

In 2001, she and Georges Joseph married in three ceremonies — a small private wedding in February, another at her south Fort Myers church in June and the last in Haiti at the pastor's own church, where about 1,000 people came to pray for them.

When her husband is in Haiti, Bernadette Joseph carries on with his work here. She volunteers at Vince Myers Ministries on Willard Street in Fort Myers, where she collects boxes of clothes to ship to Haiti. She isn't concerned that the clothes will fit perfectly. "You have needs for so many people, size is really immaterial," she said.

She writes notes thanking people for the donations and receives more supplies to add to the stacks that have taken over her home. Yolette Marie Osselin, a 46-year-old Hope Hospice nurse from Haiti, recently brought 19 backpacks stuffed with notebooks, pencils, shampoo and new underwear.

The parcels came with letters from Girl Scouts Troop 751 written in pencil on lined notebook paper adorned with stickers of butterflies and tulips.

"My name is Mason," one letter read. "I am a Girl Scout. I was born in Texas. I like all the animals in the world. What is it like in Haiti?"

■

Pastor Georges Joseph stands on a pile of concrete blocks in a lot where people toss candy wrappers and other trash. At the end of the rocky plot of land is an abandoned school bus. Its patches of yellow paint have rusted from the humid air that stirs from the Riviere Froide, a river that flows into the Bay of Port-au-Prince.

Shacks scale the ravine and surrounding hills of Carrefour. Buckets of water, dirty from dishes and washing, rotting papayas and half-eaten mangoes spoil on heaps of plastic and cardboard. When there's too much garbage, the mounds catch fire, sending plumes of gray smoke into the air. They mix with the stench of human and animal waste that comes from this river, where women wash their family's clothes and their babies.

This is where Joseph's work crew is constructing a building for some of the 97 children who live a quarter of a mile down the road at his house, which has been renamed the Good Samaritan Orphanage Salem Haiti.

"They live like sardines. It's the biggest problem that I have now," the 61-year-old said.

"Every day ... people ask me to receive some (of their) kids because they can't feed them."



■ After an exhausting trek up the mountain to the village of Bonody, Georges Joseph takes an afternoon nap. Villagers bring out a bed for the pastor and physician to sleep under jackfruit and coconut trees.

■

In 1992, Joseph and his late wife, who was a nurse, opened their two-story house to children whose parents had died or were too poor to care for them. With a gated courtyard, a second-floor porch and a large backyard, the couple thought they had plenty of space for themselves, their own children and many more. Soon after opening the home, 35 children were living at Brochette 99, Rue Libellule #2. Today, there are almost 100 — some as young as a year old.

Those who aren't orphans are sent by their parents, who know Joseph through the almost 40 clinics, churches, schools and orphanages he operates throughout Haiti. If he doesn't care for them, "they might die," he said.

At his house, children live in rooms as small as closets. About 15 teenage girls share twin mattresses in the garage. The children eat breakfast outside at two old picnic tables shaded by blue tarps. When it rains, the younger ones strip and race to the courtyard to stand under a drainpipe from the roof. They look up, spread their arms and laugh as the water drenches their tiny bodies. Because most of them bathe using buckets of water, this is the closest thing to a shower.

Just feet away, older boys study math in three cramped rooms that were supposed to house six. Instead, almost 20 sleep in each one, crammed two or three to a bed. The smaller ones lie on dirty carpet, wrap themselves with bedsheets and sleep on the floor. The rain that entertains the younger children outside floods the rooms because there is nowhere else for it to go.

Still, living here is better than the one-room shacks in villages where you have to hike for an hour to reach a main road.

"I'm good here," said 16-year-old Esaie Santilma, who came five years ago with his three brothers to the orphanage from the mountain town of Hinche. He studies math, French and science.

"I want to become a doctor," he said.

Microwave Dessables, 14, has lived at the orphanage for 10 years. He is here to go to school — and to eat, he said. He would like clothes that fit right, but he really wants a PlayStation.

In the mountains, these children would face a bleak future. "They are finished," Joseph said. "No hope."

■

About 5 a.m. one day, Joseph and his adopted son, Duplex Joazile, a police officer studying to become a pastor, carry a bag filled with lollipops, toothbrushes and bottles of aspirin to a dented Ford Taurus. The men climb into the car, close their eyes and ask Jesus for a safe trip.

For the next three hours, Joseph steers the old car around potholes and over bumps. They pass trucks hauling charcoal and chopped wood and street vendors trying desperately to sell slices of fried plantains. Finally, they park in front of a tiny yellow house where a woman fries dough by an open gate. Joazile straps on a backpack while Joseph mounts a horse that's been brought down from the mountain village of Bonody.

They begin a two-hour hike upward. When Joseph and Joazile reach the village, they stop in front of a small house shaded by mango trees. Next door is an orphanage Joseph operates with another pastor, Jean Oracius. About 30 children live there. Like the orphanage in Port-au-Prince, they sleep on the floor and a few twin beds, which serve as benches at lunch. Children attend school next door, a one-room building where the walls are chalkboards. The building also becomes a church on Sundays.

During his visit, Joseph tends to the sick. If they can pay, he charges 5 Haitian dollars — about 70 cents. In Port-au-Prince, patients pay double the price. When they cannot pay, he treats them anyway. Whatever money he collects is used to finance his mission.

Joseph examines a 51-year-old man with high blood pressure. Oracius brings his 6-year-old daughter. Her belly is swollen, and she has been vomiting. He gives her antacids and vitamins.

"It will be OK," Joseph said.

Early the next morning, Joseph and his son hike down the mountain to their car. They visit a school an hour up the road and then return to Port-au-Prince with bags of mangoes from the villagers.

When Joseph arrives home, the children race to greet him with hugs and shouts of "papi" — dad. He opens the trunk in the middle of the throng of youngsters and hands out the mangoes, which they eat like apples.

Later, Joseph explains his philosophy. It is very simple. "The more you help, the more you are blessed," he said.

■

Every few months, Joseph returns to Southwest Florida to see Bernadette and his children and visit some of the churches that support him. One Sunday in March, Pastor Joe Hanshaw invited him to speak at the Bread of Life Ministries in south Fort Myers. About 30 people sat in plush pews and listened to his story.

"*P-r-a-a-a-i-s-e* the Lord, everybody," he greeted.

Joseph explained that his father owned an 85-acre farm that he was supposed to inherit one day. Because the family was well-to-do, he attended a private Catholic school, where priests warned him against Protestants, and his father warned him against both. That's because his father practiced voodoo, a religion in which many gods and spirits are worshipped to obtain powers or cast spells. Brought to Haiti by African slaves who melded the beliefs and rites of different religious groups, voodoo is still practiced today.

One day, as a teenager, Joseph passed through a field with three circles arranged in a triangle. They were etched into the ground. After he walked across them, his leg began to ache so badly that his body writhed in pain. Three marks burned his skin, and he realized the circles were part of a voodoo curse. He was taken to a hospital, where doctors wanted to remove his leg. Joseph asked his father to send for a Protestant preacher, so he could accept Jesus into his life. After the evangelist prayed for him, the burns began to heal. That's when Joseph knew that he'd been saved for a purpose — to help the people of Haiti.

After his story that night in March, churchgoers gathered around him, placed their hands on his shoulders and prayed for him again.

"One day, you're going to see the rewards of your labor," Hanshaw said.

Later, Joseph drove two hours to Miami. The next day, he boarded a plane to return to Haiti.



■ Georges Joseph examines Inode Oracius. The 6-year-old girl suffers from an upset stomach, a common condition among villagers. Joseph gives the little girl antacids and vitamins. "It will be OK," he says.



■ Jean-Bertrand Oracius, 13, stares through a metal railing at Georges Joseph's orphanage near Port-au-Prince. His parents and younger sister live in the mountain village of Bonody where his father runs a church, school and orphanage for Joseph. Jean-Bertrand's parents sent him to live with Joseph because he can receive a better education in the city.

> "They live like sardines. It's the biggest problem that I have now. Every day ... people ask me to receive some (of their) kids because they can't feed them."
>
> ■ **Georges Joseph**
>
> A pastor and doctor who runs orphanages, schools and churches in Haiti.



■ With little to entertain themselves, girls at Pastor Georges Joseph's orphanage near Port-au-Prince pass time braiding their hair on a porch.



■ Mobbed by children at his orphanage near Port-au-Prince who greet him with shouts of "papi," dad, Georges Joseph gives them mangoes he brought back from a trip to the countryside.

HAITI'S HOPE



■ Students at the Ecole Foi Chretienne de LaJeune (School of Christian Faith of LaJeune) near Bohoc attend class. Students in different grades are often taught in the same class because there aren't enough rooms.



■ Haitian women cook lunch for students at Ecole Foi Chrætienne de LaJeune. Haitians typically cook over coals made from trees that farmers cut and burn.

A simple dream really ...

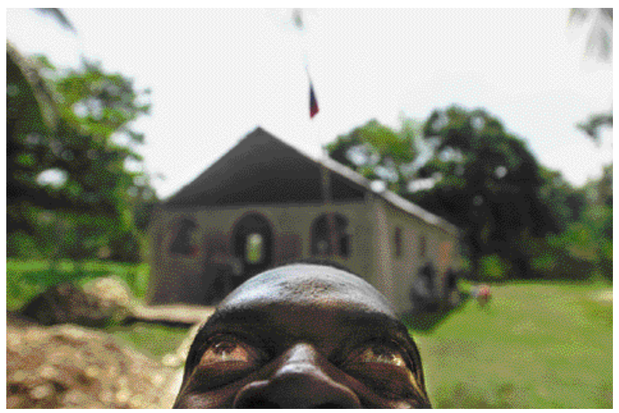
"For every Haitian to have food on the table, to be able to get up in the morning and say, 'I'm going to work and getting paid at the end of the month.' I hope that will happen."

■ **Pierrette Faustin**

Program director of the Haitian Center of Catholic Charities in Fort Myers. Although she has lived in the United States most of her life, Faustin's heart still aches for her homeland.



■ A young girl in Carrefour, a suburb of Port-au-Prince, walks along a trash-ridden path with a bucket of water on her head. She fetches the water, which will be used for cooking and bathing, at a well. Many of the homes in the sprawling neighborhood have no running water or electricity.



■ Duplex Joazile helps his adopted father, Pastor Georges Joseph, run Joseph's orphanages, churches and schools. Joazile is studying to become a pastor. Behind him is one of Joseph's schools. On Sunday, it serves as a church.